

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 145

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Herbal teas, galactagogues and everyday supplements — what's worth knowing

"Frequent, effective feeding and steady eating are the two things reliably shown to support milk supply — no tea, powder or capsule has that same evidence behind it, however it's marketed."

Why it matters now

If you're currently breastfeeding, herbal teas and "lactation" supplements are everywhere — recommended by relatives, sold at pharmacies, promoted online. It's worth knowing what's actually backed by evidence, what's traditional but unproven, and what's worth a genuine safety check before you start.

This isn't about telling you to avoid these products altogether — many are harmless at ordinary amounts. It's about making an informed choice rather than an assumed one, and knowing which single change (frequent, effective feeding) actually has the strongest evidence behind it if supply is a genuine concern.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: keep following your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — and if you're considering fenugreek specifically, check with them first, since it can lower blood glucose further alongside your medication. The A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements, and check with your pharmacist before adding any herbal or ayurvedic supplement — some can interact with thyroid medication or its absorption.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Arunachali home cooking (zan, bamboo shoot preparations, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

If you're currently breastfeeding, you've probably come across herbal teas, powders or capsules marketed to increase milk supply — often sold as "lactation" products. If you're not currently breastfeeding, the supply-related framing this week doesn't apply to you, but the general caution about supplement quality and checking with your own doctor before starting anything new still does.

Worth knowing: Most commercially marketed "lactation" teas and supplements haven't been rigorously tested for effectiveness or safety while breastfeeding. Check with your lactation consultant or doctor before starting one regularly, especially if you take any other medication.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zan, a ragi (finger millet) porridge (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Ngatok, Arunachali-style lemongrass fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Fenugreek — the most common one, and what it actually does

Fenugreek (methi) is probably the single most widely used galactagogue. The research on whether it meaningfully increases milk supply is mixed and generally weak — some small studies show an effect, others show none, and reviews have not found consistent, reliable evidence either way. A harmless side effect worth knowing about in advance: it can give sweat, urine or milk a maple-syrup-like smell, which is normal and not a sign anything is wrong.

Worth knowing: If you manage diabetes, prediabetes or take any blood-glucose-lowering medication, talk to your care team before using fenugreek regularly — it can lower blood glucose further, on top of your medication.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chura sabzi, flattened rice with vegetables, ginger and garlic (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — What's actually well-supported — feeding pattern and steady eating

The best-supported way to support milk supply isn't a tea or a supplement — it's frequent, effective milk removal (by your baby or a pump), plus eating enough across the day and staying hydrated. If supply is a genuine concern, that's worth raising directly with a lactation consultant, who can check positioning, frequency and effectiveness of removal — the things with real evidence behind them.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zan with grated vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi
- B. Ngatok, Arunachali-style lemongrass fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Reading a label — "lactation supplement" isn't a standardised category

Many herbal or ayurvedic products sold for breastfeeding mothers aren't held to the same quality or dosing standards as regulated medicines — the labelled ingredients and amounts aren't always independently verified, and "natural" doesn't automatically mean safe while breastfeeding. Where possible, choose products from brands that third-party test their supplements, check the full ingredient list rather than just the front-of-pack claim, and mention anything you're taking regularly to your doctor or lactation consultant.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Other common herbs — fennel, ajwain, jeera, shatavari

Fennel (saunf), ajwain and jeera water, and shatavari are also commonly used, often as much for their traditional digestive or comfort role as for any claimed effect on supply. At ordinary food-level amounts they're generally fine for most people; it's medicinal-strength doses or concentrated extracts — not a cup of fennel tea — that carry the more uncertain profile and are worth checking with your doctor about first, particularly if you're also on regular medication.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer bhurji, scrambled paneer with vegetables (100g paneer) with a phulka (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — What to actually ask before starting anything new

Before starting any tea, powder or capsule — herbal or otherwise — three questions are worth taking to your lactation consultant or doctor: is there any real evidence it helps, does it interact with any medication or condition you have (thyroid, diabetes, blood pressure), and is the specific product you're considering from a source that checks its own quality. Those three questions apply just as much to a multivitamin or a protein powder as to a herbal tea.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zan with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a brinjal sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zan, a ragi (finger millet) porridge (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Ngatok, Arunachali-style lemongrass fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot-and-vegetable sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Is there a tea, powder or supplement you've been taking without really knowing why — and is it worth checking on at your next appointment?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one thing this week changed about how you'll choose (or question) a supplement going forward?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

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Weekly nourishment theme

Copper and other trace minerals you don't hear as much about

"Copper, manganese and selenium are needed only in small amounts, and a varied everyday plate — nuts, seeds, whole grains, legumes, vegetables — already covers them for most people; this is about noticing that, not adding a new thing to track."

Why it matters now

This series has already covered several nutrients in their own dedicated weeks — iron, zinc, iodine, magnesium, potassium, vitamin B6, and selenium among them. A few trace minerals, copper especially, rarely get their own mention simply because true deficiency is uncommon on a reasonably varied diet. That's worth knowing explicitly, rather than leaving it unmentioned and unexplained.

The point of this week isn't to add another thing to track. It's reassurance, backed by specifics: the same everyday foods already recommended elsewhere in this series — nuts, seeds, whole grains, legumes, vegetables — cover copper, manganese and selenium for most people without any separate plan.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: keep following your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing going forward — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements — check in with your pharmacist if anything about that routine changes.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Maithil/Mithila home cooking (saagak jhor, tarua, machh-bhat, sanna, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

This series has covered several individual nutrients by now — iron, zinc, iodine, magnesium among them. A few others get far less attention simply because deficiency is uncommon when the diet is reasonably varied. Copper is the main one this week: it works alongside iron to help your body actually use the iron you take in, and supports connective tissue and nerve function.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Saagak jhor, leafy greens in a thin gravy (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Maithil-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a saagak jhor

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Where copper actually comes from

Cashews and other nuts, seeds (including sesame), whole grains, legumes, and organ meats are the main everyday sources of copper. You don't need to eat all of these daily — a reasonably varied plate across the week is enough for most people, and there's no need to track copper the way you might track iron or calcium.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Tilkor tarua, ivy gourd leaf fritters in a rice batter (4-5 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a bhajia, mixed vegetable fritters (4-5 pieces)
- B. Machh-bhat, Maithil-style fish curry with steamed rice (100g fish, 1 cup cooked rice) and a bhajia

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Manganese — a brief mention, same idea

Manganese works alongside several enzymes involved in metabolism and bone formation, and like copper it's needed in only small amounts. Whole grains, legumes, nuts and leafy greens are the main sources — largely the same everyday foods that cover copper, so there's no separate food list to remember here.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna with grated coconut (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Thadia saagak teeman, red spinach and lentils (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked)

B. Maithil-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Selenium — a quick cross-reference, not a repeat

Selenium got its own full week earlier in this series (Week 115) — the short version stays the same: your thyroid needs it in only small amounts, and Brazil nuts, fish, eggs and grains cover it easily, with no benefit to taking more than needed. If it's useful to you, that earlier week goes into more detail than there's room for here.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Arikanchanak tarkari, sun-dried colocasia leaves in a mustard gravy (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)

B. Maithil-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an arikanchanak tarkari

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi

B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — One caution — supplements, not food

Copper, manganese and selenium can all become harmful in excess, unlike from ordinary food where that's very hard to do. This is really a caution about high-dose standalone supplements rather than food — don't add a copper, manganese or selenium supplement on your own without a specific reason and your doctor's guidance, since a typical varied diet already meets these needs for most people.

Worth knowing: If you're taking a multivitamin or mineral supplement already, there's usually no need to add a separate copper, manganese or selenium supplement on top of it — check with your doctor before combining supplements.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Sanna with jaggery (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi

B. Machh-bhat, Maithil-style fish curry with steamed rice (100g fish, 1 cup cooked rice) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The everyday version of all this

None of this week's minerals need their own tracking sheet. The practical takeaway is the same one that's run through several of this series' nutrient weeks: nuts, seeds, whole grains, legumes and a varied mix of vegetables across the week, alongside your usual protein and calcium sources, covers copper, manganese and selenium for most people without any special effort.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Bhajia, mixed vegetable fritters (4-5 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Daail-jhimni, fried ribbed gourd with lentils (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Maithil-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Saagak jhor, leafy greens in a thin gravy (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Maithil-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a saagak jhor

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, does your usual plate already include nuts, seeds, whole grains and legumes fairly often — or is that a gap worth quietly closing?

Gentle weekly reflection

Is there a food from this week's list — nuts, seeds, whole grains — that you'd enjoy having more often, just because you like it?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 147

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well through batch cooking and meal prep

"A few dishes cooked once and stored safely can carry you through several genuinely nourishing days — the win is in the safe cooling, storing and reheating, as much as the cooking itself."

Why it matters now

Cooking once and eating from it over several days is one of the most practical ways to keep eating well on genuinely busy weeks — but it comes with its own set of food-safety steps that matter as much as the recipe itself.

This week is about both halves: what actually holds up well to batch cooking, freezing and reheating, and the cooling/storage/reheating practice that keeps it safe — not just convenient.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: keep following your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing going forward — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements — check in with your pharmacist if anything about that routine changes.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish

is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Old Delhi home cooking (akbari daal, korma, kebabs, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Cooking in larger batches and eating from them across the week can be a real help on busy days — but it only stays a good option if the food is cooled, stored and reheated safely. This week looks at both sides: what's worth batch-cooking, and how to do it without risk.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Akbari daal, slow-cooked urad and chana dal (3/4 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken korma (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — What batch-cooks well

Dals, bean curries (rajma, chana), most gravies and kormas, and khichdi all freeze and reheat well, generally holding their quality for about three months in the freezer if stored properly. Rice reheats well from the fridge within a day or two but is one of the foods worth the most care — more on that below. A big pot of a dal or curry made once, then portioned, is often the most efficient batch-cooking choice.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Shami kebab, minced chicken-and-lentil patties (3 pieces) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Cooling food safely before storing it

The safety of batch cooking depends heavily on this cooling step — it's the part that's easiest to skip when you're tired or busy, and the part that matters most. Smaller containers, refrigerated promptly, is the simple rule to keep in mind.

Worth knowing: Cooked food left at room temperature for more than about two hours (one hour above roughly 32°C) moves into the range where bacteria multiply fastest. Divide a large batch into smaller, shallower containers so it cools faster, and refrigerate or freeze it within that window rather than leaving the whole pot out to cool completely first.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Akbari daal (3/4 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a chicken korma side (75g chicken)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Reheating properly, and the once-only rule

Reheat stored food until it's steaming hot all the way through, not just warm — a microwave can heat unevenly, so stir partway through and check a few spots. Only reheat a portion once: reheat what you'll actually eat that sitting, rather than reheating the whole batch repeatedly and cooling it again each time, which raises the risk with every extra cycle.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg-and-vegetable bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Poha with peanuts (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi
- B. Old Delhi-style fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken korma (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — What's better cooked fresh

Not everything is worth batch-cooking. Fried or crisp items (pakoras, crisp kebabs), delicate vegetables like leafy greens, and freshly made rotis all lose texture badly on reheating — these are usually worth making closer to when you'll eat them, even on a batch-cooking day, rather than storing and reheating. A simple middle path: batch-cook the dal or curry base, and make the bread or a fresh vegetable side on the day.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Suji upma with grated vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a fresh cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken korma (100g chicken) with a phulka (2 pieces) and a fresh cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a fresh spinach sabzi
- B. Shami kebab, minced chicken-and-lentil patties (3 pieces) with a phulka (2 pieces) and a fresh spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Labelling and rotating — the practical habit that actually saves you

The most useful habit isn't a recipe at all — it's labelling containers with the date before freezing, and eating the oldest ones first. A freezer with unlabelled containers from unknown weeks doesn't actually save you time later, since it's harder to trust what's in it. A rough guide: cooked dals and curries keep about 3-4 days refrigerated or up to about 3 months frozen; cooked rice is safest used within a day from the fridge.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable daliya, broken wheat porridge (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Akbari daal (3/4 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Old Delhi-style fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or, fittingly, whatever's left from this week's batch.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Akbari daal, slow-cooked urad and chana dal (3/4 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken korma (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

If you tried batch cooking this week, did the cooling and storing steps fit into your routine, or is there a smaller version of this worth trying instead?

Gentle weekly reflection

Is there one dish from this week you'd want to keep a regular batch of in your freezer, just because it makes a busy day easier?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 148

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well when you're the one hosting or cooking for a crowd

"Serving everyone else well doesn't have to mean eating last, standing, or living off scraps from the kitchen — your own plate deserves the same planning as the guest list."

Why it matters now

Hosting or cooking for a group — family visiting, a celebration, a larger household gathering — often means everyone else eats well while the person who made it all happen eats standing up, eats last, or barely eats at all. That pattern is common enough to be worth naming directly, along with a few practical ways around it.

None of this is about doing less for your guests. It's about making sure a proper meal for yourself is part of the plan for the day, not an afterthought that depends on there being anything left over.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: keep following your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing going forward — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements — check in with your pharmacist if anything about that routine changes.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or

another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Lakshadweep home cooking (mas min/tuna curry, coconut rice, fish cutlets, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

If you're the one hosting or cooking for a gathering — family visiting, a get-together, a larger household meal — it's easy for your own eating to become an afterthought: a taste here, a bite there, and then a proper meal only once everyone else is done and the kitchen is finally quiet. This week is about protecting your own meal even while you're managing everyone else's.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Coconut rice (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Light vegetable stew (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a light vegetable stew

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Set your own plate first, before you start serving

A genuinely useful habit for a hosting day: serve your own plate at the same time as the first guest's, before the serving and re-serving begins, and set it aside if you need to keep moving. It's far easier to eat a proper meal in a pause than to try to reconstruct one later from whatever's left in the pots.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with grated coconut (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Mas min, Lakshadweep-style tuna curry (100g tuna) with coconut rice (1 cup) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — "Tasting as you cook" isn't the same as eating

A long cooking session for a crowd often means dozens of small tastes over several hours, which can feel like eating without actually covering what a full meal would. It's worth noticing that distinction on a big cooking day specifically, so a real meal doesn't quietly get skipped.

Worth knowing: It's common to assume all the tasting spoons through a long cooking session add up to a proper meal — they rarely do, and often skip protein and calcium entirely. Treat tasting as tasting, and still plan an actual sit-down portion for yourself.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Asking for a hand, without it being a whole conversation

You don't need a big discussion to get a little support on a hosting day — a simple, specific ask ("can you plate this for me while I sit for ten minutes") is often easier for people to act on than a general one. Even ten uninterrupted minutes to eat sitting down is a real difference from eating standing at the counter.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

B. Coconut rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi

B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Keeping your own food safe on a big-cooking day

It's easy to lose track of how long the serving dishes have been out when you're focused on guests — worth a quick check for your own plate too, especially anything with meat, fish, egg or dairy in it.

Worth knowing: On a day with a lot of food sitting out for guests over several hours, the same cooling and holding rules apply to your own plate as to the serving dishes: don't eat from a dish that's been sitting at room temperature for more than about two hours, and reheat anything you set aside for yourself until it's steaming hot.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a light vegetable stew

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Mas min, Lakshadweep-style tuna curry (100g tuna) with coconut rice (1 cup) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The day after — restocking yourself, not just the fridge

After a big hosting day, it's common to focus entirely on clearing up and restocking the kitchen. Worth giving your own meals the same attention the next day — a properly sized breakfast and lunch, rather than running on leftovers snatched between chores, helps you actually recover from a demanding day rather than just push through it.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Coconut rice (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Light vegetable stew (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a light vegetable stew

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Next time you're hosting, is there one small change from this week — plating your own food first, asking for ten minutes to sit — worth trying?

Gentle weekly reflection

Is there someone in your life who'd genuinely be glad to help you eat properly on a hosting day, if you simply asked?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 149

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Keeping your own eating steady when someone else in the family is unwell

"Caring well for someone who's sick doesn't require running your own meals into the ground — a few simple, low-effort options kept ready for exactly these days protect both of you."

Why it matters now

If someone else in your household — a partner, another child, an elder — is unwell right now, this week's theme applies directly. If not, keep it in mind for whenever that stretch does come up; the general habits here also work well for any period where your own routine gets pushed aside by someone else's needs.

Caring for a sick family member is real, necessary work, and it's common for a caregiver's own meals to be the first thing that slips — skipped, eaten cold, or replaced by whatever's fastest. This week is about a few low-effort ways to keep your own eating reasonably steady through exactly that kind of stretch, without adding to what's already a demanding week.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: an irregular routine can affect glucose management — follow your own plan's guidance on portions and timing, and contact your care team promptly if you can't manage your intake or glucose within it, rather than waiting to see if a hectic stretch passes. The A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements — check in with your pharmacist if a disrupted routine makes that harder to keep to some days.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Santhal Adivasi home cooking (dhuska, dal pitha, muri ghuguni, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

When a partner, another child, or an elder in your household is unwell, it's natural for your attention — and your own meals — to slide down the priority list. Appointments, medicines, extra washing and disturbed sleep can all eat into the time you'd normally spend on your own food. This week is about a few simple ways to keep your own eating reasonably steady through exactly that kind of stretch.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Muri ghuguni, puffed rice with a spiced black chickpea curry (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Keep a small stock of foods that need almost no attention

On a caregiving-heavy day, meals that require standing at the stove aren't always realistic. Worth keeping a small stock of things that need very little preparation — curd, boiled eggs made in a batch, roasted nuts, fruit, or a dal cooked earlier in the week — so a proper meal doesn't depend on having free time you don't currently have.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Dhuska, a rice-and-lentil fried disc (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Santhal-style fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Eating in shorter windows is still eating

If sitting down for a full meal isn't happening right now, several smaller eating moments across the day still add up to real nourishment — they don't need to look like a traditional three-meal pattern to count. The aim on a stretched day is getting enough food in total, not matching your usual mealtime structure exactly.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Dal pitha, steamed rice-flour dumplings with a chana dal filling (4-5 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Letting someone else's care extend to you too

If a friend, neighbour or relative offers to help while you're focused on someone else's illness, a meal for you is a genuinely practical thing to say yes to — as useful as help with errands or childcare, even though it can feel like an odd thing to ask for on someone else's behalf. It doesn't have to be a big ask; even a single cooked dish shared over is real support.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Chana dal cheela, savoury lentil pancakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi

B. Santhal-style fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Watching your own signs too, not only theirs

It's easy to become entirely focused on the unwell family member's symptoms and appointments and lose track of your own wellbeing in the process. Checking in with yourself — sleep, appetite, mood — a couple of times through a longer stretch of caregiving is worth doing deliberately, since it's not something that tends to happen on its own.

Worth knowing: Prolonged disturbed sleep, skipped meals and high stress can affect you as well as whoever you're caring for — persistent exhaustion, a marked drop in your own appetite over several days, or feeling unable to cope are worth mentioning to your own doctor, not just pushed through silently because someone else's needs feel more urgent right now.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi

B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Once things settle, rebuilding your own routine gently

As the immediate caregiving intensity eases — the person recovers, appointments become less frequent — it's a good moment to rebuild your own eating routine deliberately rather than assuming it'll snap back on its own. A few consistent meals across a few days is usually enough to feel steadier again.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Muri ghuguni, puffed rice with a spiced black chickpea curry (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

If this stretch is still ongoing, is there one small thing from this week — a stocked shelf, a single ask for help — worth putting in place today?

Gentle weekly reflection

Looking after someone else well doesn't mean looking after yourself less — is there one meal this week that felt like it was genuinely for you?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 150

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well through a move or a big change in your surroundings

"An unfamiliar kitchen and an unpacked pantry are temporary — a few simple, low-equipment meals can carry you through the unsettled stretch until your routine catches up with your new surroundings."

Why it matters now

If you're currently moving house, relocating, or otherwise going through a big change to your everyday surroundings, this week's theme applies directly. If not, keep it in mind for whenever that stretch does come up — the same low-equipment, gradually-rebuilding approach works for any period where your usual kitchen and routine aren't available to you.

A move disrupts far more than furniture — it can disrupt where your food comes from, what you're able to cook, and how settled you feel doing it. This week is about a realistic, temporary way through that, not a demand to have everything running smoothly from the first day in a new place.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: an irregular routine can affect glucose management — follow your own plan's guidance on portions and timing, and contact your care team promptly if you can't manage your intake or glucose within it during an unsettled stretch. The A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep following your prescribed medication timing around meals and calcium or iron supplements even while things are unsettled — check in with your pharmacist if a house move disrupts your usual supply or routine.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Puducherry/Franco-Tamil home cooking (meen kuzhambu, mor kuzhambu, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

A house move, a relocation, or any big change to your everyday surroundings can genuinely disrupt eating for a while — packed-up cookware, an unfamiliar kitchen, an unfamiliar local market, and simply not knowing where anything is yet. This week is about keeping yourself fed reasonably well through that in-between stretch, not about having it perfectly figured out from day one.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Puducherry idli, slightly sweet idlis (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Lemon rice (1 cup) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken vindal, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Mutton sambar, a mutton-and-lentil curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Before the kitchen is unpacked — a short list of no-cook basics

In the first few days of a move, cooking might not be possible at all. A short list of no-cook, minimal-equipment basics is worth having in mind: curd, milk, boiled eggs (if you can access even a kettle or borrow a stove briefly), fruit, roasted nuts, and bread. These cover protein and calcium reasonably well without needing a functioning kitchen.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Curd (150g) with a banana and roasted peanuts (15g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Meen kuzhambu, tamarind-and-coconut fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Finding your new local sources, gradually

Locating a reliable dairy source, a usual grocery or vegetable seller, and a pharmacy in a new area doesn't need to happen all at once — prioritising a dependable milk or curd source early on is worth it, since it anchors the calcium habit this series keeps coming back to, even while the rest of your routine is still settling.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Appam, fermented rice pancakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a rajma curry (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Chicken vindail, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, plus carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Eating out more than usual, for now

It's common to eat out or order in more than usual around a move, simply because cooking isn't set up yet. That's a reasonable, temporary adjustment rather than something to feel bad about — where possible, choose options with a clear protein source (dal, egg, paneer, meat or fish) and a vegetable side, rather than only bread or rice-based dishes, to keep the week's usual balance roughly on track.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)
- B. Lemon rice (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi
- B. Mutton sambar, a mutton-and-lentil curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken vindail, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Food safety in an unfamiliar kitchen

An unfamiliar stove, fridge or water source is worth a bit of extra attention in the first days, purely from a food-safety standpoint — the same care you'd already give your usual kitchen, just not yet on autopilot in a new one.

Worth knowing: A borrowed, rented or brand-new kitchen may have appliances you haven't used before — check a fridge's actual temperature rather than assuming it's cold enough, and be a little more cautious with anything that needs proper refrigeration until you're confident it's working as expected.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Lemon rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Mor kuzhambu, a spiced buttermilk-and-coconut curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Chicken vindail, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mor kuzhambu side

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Meen kuzhambu, tamarind-and-coconut fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Rebuilding a routine, once the essentials are unpacked

Once the kitchen basics are unpacked and working, rebuilding a simple eating routine — even just a dependable breakfast and a planned dinner — tends to settle the rest of the day too. It doesn't need to be your old routine exactly; a new one that fits your new surroundings is just as valid.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Parotta, a flaky layered flatbread (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Lemon rice (1 cup) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken vindal, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus peas and carrots) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Puducherry idli, slightly sweet idlis (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Lemon rice (1 cup) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken vindal, tangy slow-cooked chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Mutton sambar, a mutton-and-lentil curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

If a move is still ahead of you or still settling, is there one no-cook basic from this week worth keeping on hand for the first few days?

Gentle weekly reflection

Is there something about a new kitchen or a new neighbourhood you're genuinely looking forward to, once the unsettled part has passed?

Looking ahead

Next week continues within Phase 5 of 6 — everyday nourishment for you, well beyond the first year.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.